The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP

Donald Trump threatened to strike Iranian power plants and bridges on Tuesday if Iran's regime did not "open the fuckin' strait". This is the third time Mr Trump has threatened to attack civilian infrastructure, something which is generally considered a war crime under international law. Earlier Mr Trump boasted aboutin the rescue of an American airman shot down by Iran on Friday.

Meanwhile **Israel's** defence minister warned of intensifying attacks on assets related to **Iran's petrochemical industry**. He claimed that the sector, having generated roughly $18bn in two years, "directly serves" to finance Iranian missile production. On Saturday Iran reported that Israeli missiles had effectively shut down one of the country's largest petrochemical complexes and struck the area around its sole nuclear power-plant for the fourth time in the war.

Iran has yet to respond to America's rescue mission. A senior Iranian military leader warned America and Israel earlier that "the gates of hell would be opened" should they attack his country's **energy infrastructure**. On Saturday Iran launched a wave of strikes at targets in the region. **Kuwait** said Iranian drones had

struck two power and water-desalination plants, causing "significant damage". No casualties were reported.

European policymakers are privately pushing back against new **windfall taxes** on big oil, labelling the measures as premature, a source close to the negotiations told *The Economist*. The finance ministers of **Austria**, **Germany**, **Italy**, **Portugal** and **Spain** called for windfall taxes on oil firms amid an energy shock triggered by the war in Iran. In a letter they urged for "those who profit from the consequences of war" to "do their part". The European Commission is working on "targeted policy measures", a spokesperson said.

The Trump administration said it would ask for a significant rise in **defence spending** in its **budget request** to Congress for fiscal 2027. The request includes $1.5trn in military funding, a rise of more than 40% compared with the previous year. The administration said it would partly offset the increase with cuts of $73bn to non-military spending.

NASA released images of Earth taken by **astronauts** on board the Orion spacecraft that will fly around the **Moon** as part of the Artemis II mission. The craft is now closer to the Moon than it is to Earth; it is on track to arrive early next week. This crew is the first to leave Earth's orbit since 1972.

Word of the week: "workslop", the unnecessary AI-generated slop that is produced when bosses tell employees they must use the technology. Read Ethan Mollick's guest essay on why employers should treat AI as what it is: weird.

Photograph: Getty Images

A symbolic decision for OPEC

Sunday's monthly meeting of representatives from the Organisation of the Petroleum Exporting Countries and its allies, who are collectively responsible for 40% of all oil output, will be closely watched. With the Strait of Hormuz largely closed, 15% of the world's oil cannot reach its customers. OPEC's decision in March to boost output by 206,000 barrels per day, equivalent to about 0.2% of global supply, was barely a drop in the bucket. The oil shock is intensifying alongside the conflict. On Friday Iran struck one of Kuwait's largest refineries, normally capable of producing 346,000 barrels a day.

OPEC is thought to be considering making at least the same increase again. But because many of the group's members are in the Gulf, many extra barrels from them will remain stuck. Until the strait is passable, any additional production will only really exist on paper.

Photograph: EPA

The American pontiff’s first Easter

Pope Leo celebrated Easter mass on Sunday for the first time as leader of the world’s 1.4bn baptised Roman Catholics. In his traditional address afterwards—made to the world, as well as the city of Rome—Leo appealed for peace. “Let those who have weapons lay them down! Let those who have the power to unleash wars choose peace!”, he said. Leo did not mention the attack on Iran directly. But America’s first pope has recently become more forthright in his condemnation of some of the Trump administration’s policies.

In church politics, meanwhile, the 70-year-old pontiff has moved cautiously. Beyond filling his previous post, Leo has made only one high-level Vatican appointment since his election last May. And he has generally tried to appease the sensibilities of Catholic traditionalists without discarding the liberal approach of his predecessor, Francis, to such issues as immigration, climate and poverty. It is a delicate balancing act.

Photograph: AFP

Beating high egg prices

The price of eggs has fallen by around 60% in America since this time last year, when a dozen cost a record $6.23 on average. This will be a relief for Americans celebrating Easter with cakes, dyed eggs and other eggstravagances. An outbreak of avian flu has wiped out hundreds of millions of chickens in both America and Europe since 2022, squeezing egg supplies. To beat henflation, the Trump administration imported over 650% more eggs last year than the year before—many from Turkey (the country) and Brazil.

While the virus continues to rage, global flocks are slowly recovering. But the egg business is sensitive to the cost of electricity, needed to light barns, and grain, used for chicken feed. Prices in Europe remain high, and the war in Iran may batter the industry. This week an egg in the Netherlands cost a record €0.35 ($0.41)—bad news for those hoping to gorge on *Paashaasjes*, a bready bunny-shaped treat, this weekend.

Photograph: Getty Images

AI comes for the arts

Does it matter if artists use AI? Bob Dylan, an American songwriter and Nobel literature laureate, has started publishing short stories, audio essays and fictional letters by historical figures on Patreon, a subscription platform. Mr Dylan has not commented beyond some cryptic posts on social media. But his fans are getting stirred up because some of the audio recordings seem to have been generated by AI.

Bots are not talented artists, but they are not necessarily worse than humans. “Shy Girl”, a buzzy horror novel, was recently withdrawn by its publisher before its American release after vigilante readers with bot-busting software detected signs of machine involvement. (Mia Ballard, the author, denies using AI.) Lots of the prose was derivative, but some of it was good, and many readers enjoyed it. Expect plenty more such controversies. As a younger Mr Dylan wrote (himself): “You don’t need a weatherman, to know which way the wind blows.”

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Nancy Dixon, Kansas City, Missouri, America
Iskriyana Vasileva, Berlin, Germany
Dervla Batt, Dublin, Ireland

They gave the correct answers of John Stennis, George H.W. Bush, Harry Truman, Chester Nimitz and Gerald Ford. The theme is that they all have current US aircraft carriers named after them.

The questions were

Monday: Richard Nixon proposed which long-running Mississippi Senator, who suffered from poor hearing, as an intermediary who should listen to the Watergate tapes and summarise them for investigators?

Tuesday: Who served as both America's ambassador to the United Nations and director of the CIA in the 1970s?

Wednesday: Who was the only American president to be born in Missouri?

Thursday: Which Admiral was selected to be commander of the US Pacific fleet in the wake of the Pearl Harbour attacks?

Friday: Which American president pardoned Richard Nixon?

Hell is truth seen too late.

Thomas Hobbes